

The Fallen Liturgies of American Politics

A Minimal Spiritual-Ecosystem Diagnosis of National Polarization

1. The Trap of Singular Diagnosis

The sickness of American politics cannot be explained by diagnosing one man, one party, one ideology, or one election. To reduce the disorder of a whole people to Donald Trump's psychology is already to participate in the disorder: it converts a systemic spiritual pathology into a personality drama.

Trump is not irrelevant. He is a catalyst, mirror, amplifier, and priestly figure within one of the dominant political liturgies. But he did not create the hunger. He stepped into an already-open vacuum: a people longing for protection, vengeance, belonging, purification, and meaning.

The deeper problem is not one leader. The deeper problem is that the American body politic has lost a shared submission to reality. The Logos no longer governs the common word. Public speech no longer names what is. Language becomes weapon, mask, spell, slogan, simulation, and tribal signal.

When the common word breaks, politics ceases to be deliberation over shared goods. It becomes a war of false liturgies.

2. Created Goods and Fallen Powers

Each political faction begins with a real created good. None is pure evil at the root. The problem is that each good becomes isolated from the whole order of creation, inflated into an idol, and animated by a fallen Power.

A created good becomes demonic when it claims ultimacy.

Belonging becomes possession.
Justice becomes purification.
Order becomes control.
Freedom becomes disembodiment.
Protection becomes sacrifice.
Speech becomes spellcraft.
The nation becomes Leviathan.
The enemy becomes Azazel.
The body politic becomes Beast.

The current political crisis is therefore not merely ideological. It is liturgical. Each faction trains its adherents to perceive reality through a different fallen form.

3. The Four Colliding False Liturgies

A. The Right-Populist Fantasy: The Purified Body

The created good here is real: love of place, memory, family, inherited culture, loyalty, borders, embodied peoplehood, and the need to protect a community from dissolution.

But when fallen, this good becomes the fantasy of the Pure Body Politic.

The nation is imagined as a sacred organism that was once whole but has been infected by outsiders, bureaucrats, elites, foreigners, liberals, immigrants, sexual disorder, demographic change, or cultural betrayal. The central illusion is that the nation can be healed by purging contamination.

This is Leviathan experienced as wounded body.

The false word is:

We were whole until they infected us.

This liturgy tends toward Ba'al, because it says, "You belong to the nation." It tends toward Azazel, because it transfers guilt onto outsiders and traitors. It tends toward the Beast, because it wraps the national body in spectacle: flags, rallies, chants, strongman images, sacred nostalgia, martyr stories, and myths of lost greatness.

Its savior figure is the un-cancelable protector patriarch: the one who cannot be shamed, cannot be removed, cannot be domesticated by polite institutional speech. He becomes the symbolic immune system of the imagined national body.

But this is not renewal under Christ. It is counterfeit resurrection through domination.

B. The Radical-Left Fantasy: The Purified Future

The created good here is also real: justice for the oppressed, exposure of hypocrisy, concern for victims, hatred of domination, and the prophetic instinct to name hidden cruelty.

But when fallen, this good becomes the fantasy of the Utopian Reset.

The world is imagined as infinitely malleable. Human nature, language, sex, history, memory, family, tradition, and civilization become raw material for moral reconstruction. The illusion is that suffering can be eliminated if the right language is enforced, the right structures are dismantled, and the right identities are affirmed.

The false word is:

We can redeem the world by renaming it.

This is a counterfeit Logos. It recognizes that words shape reality, but it severs the word from the given order of creation. Speech becomes not truthful naming but magical reconstruction.

Its liturgy is confession without absolution, accusation without atonement, repentance without forgiveness, justice without mercy, and purification without resurrection.

Its enemy is not merely injustice but finitude itself: the limits of body, sex, history, inheritance, tragedy, and creatureliness. It seeks a purified future by erasing the contaminated past.

But creation cannot be redeemed by pretending it was never given. The future cannot be made holy by hatred of the created order.

C. The Institutional Fantasy: The Managed Order

The created good here is law, procedure, expertise, restraint, institutional memory, due process, administrative competence, and the attempt to keep violence from devouring public life.

But when fallen, this good becomes the fantasy of the Endless End of History.

The illusion is that society can be managed indefinitely by norms, courts, credentials, data, agencies, markets, think tanks, fact-checking, expert consensus, and procedural legitimacy. The Institutionalists believe chaos can be suppressed if everyone agrees to speak in the language of responsible management.

The false word is:

If the process holds, reality is redeemed.

This is order without repentance. It sees disorder but cannot name sin. It sees extremism but cannot name the Powers. It sees breakdown but assumes the cure is better administration.

Its liturgy is the meeting, the memo, the credential, the ruling, the white paper, the committee, the consensus panel, the managed statement, the respectable opinion.

The danger here is not wild violence but deadness. The living moral crisis is translated into procedure. Tragedy is converted into policy language. Spiritual conflict is reduced to institutional malfunction.

This is not the Logos. It is the letter without spirit.

D. The Tech-Libertarian Fantasy: The Disembodied Sovereign

The created good here is creativity, invention, decentralization, voluntary association, resistance to tyranny, and the human desire to build tools that extend freedom.

But when fallen, this good becomes the fantasy of the Sovereign Individual.

The illusion is that the physical, political, and social world can be bypassed. The body can be optimized. The state can be routed around. The neighbor can be replaced by network. The city can be replaced by platform. The earth can be abandoned for Mars. Mortality can be delayed. Community can be simulated. Reality can be coded.

The false word is:

I can be free without belonging to anyone.

This is a gnostic temptation inside technological form. It seeks salvation by escape from embodiment, limits, dependency, place, obligation, and the agonizing compromises of shared life.

Its liturgy is optimization, exit, disruption, decentralization, biohacking, simulation, acceleration, and transcendence through code.

But code is not Logos. A network is not communion. Exit is not resurrection. The sovereign individual is not free if he has merely escaped the neighbor.

4. Why the System Cannot Heal Itself

These four factions do not merely disagree about policy. They are not simply arguing about taxes, schools, immigration, war, speech, markets, or technology.

They are trying to force the country to live inside their preferred defense mechanism.

The Right-Populist says: be purified by return.

The Radical Left says: be purified by reconstruction.

The Institutionalists says: be stabilized by procedure.

The Tech-Utopian says: be liberated by exit.

Each contains a partial truth. Each protects a created good. Each becomes destructive when it claims to be the whole.

This is why compromise becomes nearly impossible. A healthy democracy bargains over finite goods. A sick democracy wages metaphysical war. Once each faction believes the others are not merely wrong but existentially contaminating, politics becomes scapegoat ritual.

The Right sees the Left as infection.

The Left sees the Right as evil.

The Institutionalists see both as irrational threats to order.

The Tech-Utopians quietly build escape hatches from the whole shared world.

The result is not merely polarization. It is a fractured symbolic order.

5. The Nation-State as the Arena of the Powers

The American nation-state is not one Power but a constellation of Powers.

As Leviathan, it presents itself as the great body that must survive.

As Ba'al, it claims ownership over bodies, loyalty, citizenship, and sacrifice.

As Beast, it stages sacred spectacle through flags, myths, offices, rituals, monuments, enemies, and national memory.

As Dragon, it is animated by fear, domination, emergency, and the belief that violence saves.

As Moloch, it consumes the young in war, debt, despair, and sacrificial political machinery.

As Azazel, it transfers guilt onto enemies, outsiders, traitors, deplorables, elites, oppressors, immigrants, extremists, or whatever body can be made to carry the nation's shame.

American politics is therefore not only a contest for state power. It is a struggle over which principality will interpret the national body.

Who gets to name the infection?

Who gets to name the victim?

Who gets to name the savior?

Who gets to name the sacrifice?

Who gets to say what reality is?

That is why language is now central. The political war is a war over the word.

6. The Ecclesia as Counter-Politics

The answer is not withdrawal into private spirituality. Nor is it capture of the state in the name of God. Both are temptations.

The Ecclesia is the called assembly of believers whose life bears witness to the true Logos in history. It is not the nation. It is not a utopian class. It is not a bureaucracy. It is not a platform. It is not the purified body politic. It is not the perfected future. It is not the managed order. It is not the sovereign individual.

The Ecclesia is a people gathered under The Son, animated by the Holy Spirit, and disciplined by truthful speech, forgiveness, embodied love, and allegiance to the Kingdom of God.

Against the Right-Populist fantasy, the Ecclesia says: no nation is the Body of Christ.

Against the Radical-Left fantasy, the Ecclesia says: creation is wounded but still given.

Against the Institutional fantasy, the Ecclesia says: order without spirit cannot save.

Against the Tech-Utopian fantasy, the Ecclesia says: freedom is not escape from embodiment but redeemed communion.

The Ecclesia does not redeem politics by becoming another faction. It witnesses to a different order.

7. Return to Reality

The cure is not one leader, one election, one revolution, one institution, one platform, or one purified ideology.

The cure begins with a return to reality.

No leader can save us.

No nation is holy in itself.

No revolution can abolish human finitude.

No bureaucracy can eliminate sin.

No technology can free us from creatureliness.

No enemy can carry away our guilt.

No sacrifice to Leviathan can resurrect the dead.

Reality is not created by political fantasy. Reality is received, named, confessed, and redeemed under The Son.

American politics is sick because its factions have become rival liturgies of salvation. Each offers a counterfeit gospel. Each promises redemption without the cross, purification without repentance, order without conversion, freedom without love, and resurrection without Christ.

The task is therefore not merely to depolarize. The task is to discern the Powers, refuse their false words, recover truthful speech, and live as a people whose common life is ordered not by fear, scapegoating, control, or escape, but by the Logos made flesh.

Only then can politics become finite again.

And finite politics is the only politics that does not demand worship.